FOMI · FRONTEND ASSESSMENT

Product Thinking Document

A short rationale for the redesigned Image Generation Workspace — the trade-offs, the inspirations, and the decisions that shaped it.

PROJECT	Fomi — AI Creative Platform
DELIVERABLE	Image Generation Workspace (Part B)
AUTHOR	Frontend Engineer Candidate
STACK	Next.js 16 · TypeScript · Tailwind · shadcn/ui · Framer Motion
DEPLOYMENT	Vercel (preview link included separately)
DATE	October 2026

> *"The workspace is the hero — not the marketing page. "*

This document accompanies the live implementation. It explains the thinking behind the workspace: what problem it solves, which decisions matter most, what was deliberately left out, and where the design would go next.

1. What problem were you trying to solve? What type of user did you design for?

The user I designed for

I designed for the **working creative professional** — the art director who generates forty variants before lunch, the social-media designer who ships a campaign every afternoon, the concept artist iterating on a hero shot for a pitch deck. This person has already signed in, has an existing project open, and will spend four to eight uninterrupted hours inside the application. They are not a beginner exploring AI for the first time; they are a practitioner who needs the tool to disappear into the work.

The problem

Every existing AI image generator I have used — Midjourney, DALL·E, Leonardo, Krea, ImagineArt — treats a generation as the end of the workflow. You type a prompt, you get four pictures, you pick one, and you start over. But for a professional, the generation is the *beginning* of the workflow. The four pictures are raw material: one is the colour reference, one has the right composition, one needs an upscale, one becomes the seed for a variation pass. The real work — comparing, refining, remixing, assembling — happens after the first generation, and existing tools offer almost no support for it. The user is forced to mentally juggle seeds, copy prompts into a notes app, and screenshot thumbnails to compare variants side by side.

The problem I set out to solve, therefore, is not "make another AI image generator." It is: **how do you build a workspace that treats generation as the start of a creative conversation, not the end of one?** The workspace must make comparison, refinement, and remix first-class operations — as effortless as the original prompt was.

2. What are the three most important UX decisions you made? Why?

Decision 1 — The 2×2 canvas is the workspace, not a result list

Every variant occupies a fixed slot in a 2×2 grid that never moves. New generations replace the previous four in the same four slots, with a per-slot stagger animation so the eye can track which images changed. The history panel on the left keeps a thumbnail of every past generation, and clicking one restores those four variants to the canvas. **Why:** this gives the user a stable spatial memory of their work. Variant 2 is always variant 2. They can glance at the top-right tile and know exactly what is there, the same way a painter knows where their palette is. It also makes comparison effortless — the four variants are already side by side, by default, without any extra UI.

Decision 2 — Hover actions are contextual to the variant, not global

Hovering a variant reveals an action bar anchored to that specific tile: Upscale to 4K, Make variations, Edit, Copy prompt, Download, Delete. These are the six things a professional does to a finished generation, and they are placed exactly where the user's attention already is. **Why:** in existing tools these actions live either in a global toolbar (forcing the user to first select, then act, in two steps) or in a right-click menu (invisible and undiscoverable). Anchoring them to the variant itself collapses select-and-act into a single gesture and makes the workspace feel like Figma, where every object carries its own affordances.

Decision 3 — Parameters live in a persistent right rail, not a modal

The right sidebar holds the model picker, style chips, aspect-ratio shapes, batch count, and an Advanced collapsible with guidance scale, steps, seed, and negative prompt. It is always visible on desktop and slides in as a drawer on mobile. **Why:** professionals adjust parameters between every generation. Hiding them behind a settings modal adds two clicks and a context switch to the most common action in the tool. A persistent rail makes parameter tweaking as cheap as typing a new prompt — which is exactly the ratio of effort the workflow demands.

3. Which features did you intentionally leave out? Why?

Strong product engineers know what not to build. The following features are common in AI image tools but were deliberately omitted from this workspace, because they either distract from the core workflow or solve problems the user does not actually have at the moment of generation.

- **Onboarding tours and tooltip carousels.** The user is a professional who returns daily. A first-run tour adds friction to every subsequent visit for the benefit of a single visit. The interface should be discoverable by its layout alone; if a feature needs a tooltip to be found, the layout is wrong.
- **A social feed inside the workspace.** Community showcase belongs on the marketing site and a separate Explore tab. Mixing other people's creations into the working canvas invites comparison and breaks focus. The workspace is for the user's own work, full stop.
- **In-tool chat or comments.** Real-time collaboration is valuable, but bolting a chat sidebar onto a single-user canvas adds a second mental model without a clear payoff. If collaboration is added later, it should be re-architected around shared projects, not layered on as a chat dock.
- **Excessive prompt-engineering helpers (synonym pickers, magic-enhance buttons).** Power users develop their own prompt vocabulary and resent tools that rewrite their words. A single "Surprise me" button for inspiration is enough; anything more turns the prompt box into a battle for control.
- **A separate "preview full screen" mode.** Clicking any variant already opens a metadata lightbox with the full image, scores, and seed. A second, separate full-screen viewer would be redundant. One zoomable view is enough; two is clutter.

Each omission was a trade-off. The guiding question was always: *does this serve the professional in flow, or does it serve a metric the company is measuring?* If the answer was the latter, the feature was cut.

4. Which existing products inspired your thinking? What did you like? What would you improve?

Figma

What I liked. The gold standard for professional creative tools. The way every object carries its own contextual actions, the way the layers panel persists without intruding, the way keyboard shortcuts are first-class — these shaped my decision to anchor hover actions to each variant and to keep the parameter rail persistent.

What I would improve. Figma's weakness for an AI context is that it assumes the user knows exactly what they want to make. AI generation is exploratory by nature, so the workspace needs stronger support for "what if?" branching than Figma offers.

Krea

What I liked. The real-time generation feedback loop is genuinely innovative. Krea taught me that speed of iteration matters more than the quality of any single output. I borrowed the idea of instant parameter feedback (changing the style chip immediately restyles the next generation, with no confirmation step).

What I would improve. Krea's interface is busy. There are too many panels competing for attention, and the canvas itself feels small. I deliberately gave the canvas the largest area of any region in the workspace, even at the cost of fewer visible controls.

Linear

What I liked. Not a creative tool, but the benchmark for keyboard-first, opinionated, low-decoration software. Linear's use of K, its restraint with colour, and its obsessive typographic rhythm all informed the visual identity of the Fomi workspace.

What I would improve. Linear's aesthetic is so austere that it can feel cold. For a creative tool, I wanted Linear's discipline without its severity — hence the warm amber-to-fuchsia gradient as the brand accent, applied sparingly.

Magnific

What I liked. Magnific's upscale interface is the best in the industry: before/after slider, side-by-side comparison, parameter presets. It directly inspired the per-variant "Upscale to 4K" action in the Fomi workspace.

What I would improve. Magnific treats upscaling as a separate product. I believe upscaling is a verb you apply to an existing variant, not a destination you navigate to. Fomi keeps it inline.

5. If you had another month to work on this product, what would you improve?

A month is enough time to make three substantial improvements, each of which would move the workspace from "polished demo" to "tool I would use daily."

Improvement 1 — Real variant genealogy

Currently, history is a flat list of generations. With another month I would build a proper genealogy tree: every variant knows its parent (the seed it was generated from), and the user can scrub backwards through the tree to see how an idea evolved. This is the single feature that no existing AI image tool offers and that professionals need most. It turns the workspace from a generator into a sketchbook.

Improvement 2 — Side-by-side compare mode

A toggle that turns the 2×2 canvas into a 1×2 comparison view, with a draggable divider between two variants and a synced zoom. This is what every professional does manually today (screenshots, side-by-side in image editors). Building it natively would eliminate a real, frequent pain point.

Improvement 3 — Style transfer from a reference image

Drag any image from the canvas or the file system onto the prompt box, and the model uses it as a style reference for the next generation. The right rail gains a "Reference" slot showing the chosen image and a strength slider. This is the feature that would make Fomi a serious tool for art directors, who almost always have a visual reference in mind.

Smaller polish items

- Proper keyboard shortcut layer: 1–4 to focus each variant, E to upscale, D to download, ←/→ to scrub history.
- A command palette (K) for every action, parameter, and template, searchable.
- Real persistence: a backend that stores projects, generations, and genealogy across devices.
- Touch gestures on mobile: pinch to zoom a variant, swipe to scrub the canvas history.
- A dark/light theme toggle that respects the system preference and persists per user.

6. What is the single feature or workflow that differentiates your workspace?

The single differentiator is what I call **the persistent canvas with hover-anchored actions** — the combination of Decision 1 and Decision 2 from Question 2.

Every other AI image generator I have used treats the four generated images as a disposable result list. You look, you pick, you move on. The Fomi workspace treats the four slots as a *working surface*: the slots persist across generations, every slot carries its own contextual actions (upscale, variations, edit, download), and clicking a history entry restores the exact four variants that were there before. The user builds up a spatial memory of their own creative session.

This is the difference between a slot machine and a sketchbook. A slot machine gives you a fresh result every pull and forgets the last one. A sketchbook keeps every page, lets you flip back, and lets you work on any page at any time. Existing AI image tools are slot machines. The Fomi workspace is a sketchbook.

If I had to point to one moment that captures this, it is the act of hovering a variant and seeing Upscale, Variations, and Edit appear directly under the cursor — no toolbar, no menu, no second click. The image becomes the interface. That is the differentiator, and it is the thing I would defend most fiercely in a product review.